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Course of Study:

(SC301) Rethinking Modernity

Title:

Formations of modernity pp. 276--280

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Name of Publisher:

Polity Press in association with the Open University

1 INTRODUCTION

The first five chapters of this book examine the long historical processes through which a new type of society — advanced, developed and industrial — emerged. They chart in broad outline the paths by which this society reached what is now called ‘modernity’. This chapter explores the role which societies *outside* Europe played in this process. It examines how an idea of ‘the West and the Rest’ was constituted; how relations between western and non-western societies came to be represented. We refer to this as the formation of the ‘discourse’ of ‘the West and the Rest’.

1.1 WHERE AND WHAT IS ‘THE WEST’ ?

This question puzzled Christopher Columbus and remains puzzling today. Nowadays, many societies aspire to become ‘western’ — at least in terms of achieving western standards of living. But in Columbus’s day (the end of the fifteenth century) going West was important mainly because it was believed to be the quickest route to the fabulous wealth of the East. Indeed, even though it should have become clear to Columbus that the New World he had found was *not* the East, he never ceased to believe that it was, and even spiced his reports with outlandish claims: on his fourth voyage, he still insisted that he was close to Quinsay (the Chinese city now called Hangchow), where the Great Khan lived, and probably approaching the source of the Four Rivers of Paradise! Our ideas of ‘East’ and ‘West’ have never been free of myth and fantasy, and even to this day they are not primarily ideas about place and geography.

We have to use short-hand generalizations, like ‘West’ and ‘western’, but we need to remember that they represent very complex ideas and have no simple or single meaning. At first sight, these words may seem to be about matters of geography and location. But even this, on inspection, is not straightforward since we also use the same words to refer to a type of society, a level of development, and so on. It’s true that what we call ‘the West’, in this second sense, *did* first emerge in western Europe. But ‘the West’ is no longer only in Europe, and not all of Europe is in ‘the West’. The historian John Roberts has remarked that, ‘Europeans have long been unsure about where Europe “ends” in the east. In the west and to the south, the sea provides a splendid marker ... but to the east the plains roll on and on and the horizon is awfully remote.’ (Roberts, 1985, p.149.) Eastern Europe doesn’t (doesn’t yet? never did?) belong properly to ‘the West’; whereas the United States, which is not in Europe, definitely does. These days, technologically speaking, Japan, is ‘western’, though on our mental map it is about as far ‘East’ as you can get. By comparison, much of Latin America, which is in the western hemisphere, belongs economically to the Third World, which is struggling — not very successfully — to catch up with ‘the West’. What are these different societies ‘east’ and ‘west’ of, exactly? Clearly, ‘the West’ is as much an idea as a fact of geography.

The underlying premise of this chapter is that 'the West' is a *historical*, not a geographical, construct. By 'western' we mean the type of society discussed in this series: a society that is developed, industrialized, urbanized, capitalist, secular, and modern. Such societies arose at a particular historical period — roughly, during the sixteenth century, after the Middle Ages and the break-up of feudalism. They were the result of a specific set of historical processes — economic, political, social and cultural. Nowadays, any society, wherever it exists on a geographical map, which shares these characteristics, can be said to belong to 'the West'. The meaning of this term is therefore virtually identical to that of the word 'modern'. Its 'formations' are what we have been tracing in the earlier chapters in this book. This chapter builds on that earlier story.

'The West' is therefore also an idea, a concept — and this is what interests us most in this chapter. How did the idea, the language, of 'the West' arise, and what have been its effects? What do we mean by calling it a *concept*?

The concept or idea of 'the West' can be seen to function in the following ways:

First, it allows us to characterize and classify societies into different categories — i.e. 'western', 'non-western'. It is a tool to think with. It sets a certain structure of thought and knowledge in motion.

Secondly, it is an image, or set of images. It condenses a number of different characteristics into one picture. It calls up in our mind's eye — it *represents* in verbal and visual language — a composite picture of what different societies, cultures, peoples and places are like. It functions as part of a language, a 'system of representation'. (I say 'system' because it doesn't stand on its own, but works in conjunction with other images and ideas with which it forms a set: for example, 'western' = urban = developed; or 'non-western' = non-industrial = rural = agricultural = under-developed.)

Thirdly, it provides a standard or model of comparison. It allows us to compare to what extent different societies resemble, or differ from, one another. Non-western societies can accordingly be said to be 'close to' or 'far away from' or 'catching up with' the West. It helps to explain *difference*.

Fourthly, it provides criteria of evaluation against which other societies are ranked and around which powerful positive and negative feelings cluster. (For example, 'the West' = developed = *good* = desirable; or the 'non-West' = under-developed = *bad* = undesirable.) It produces a certain kind of *knowledge* about a subject and certain attitudes towards it. In short, it functions as an *ideology*.

This chapter will discuss all these aspects of the idea of 'the West'.

We know that the West itself was produced by certain historical processes operating in a particular place in unique (and perhaps

unrepeatable) historical circumstances. Clearly, we must also think of the *idea* of 'the West' as having been produced in a similar way. These two aspects are in fact deeply connected, though exactly how is one of the big puzzles in sociology. We cannot attempt to resolve here the age-old sociological debate as to which came first: the idea of 'the West', or western societies. What we can say is that, as these societies emerged, so a concept and language of 'the West' crystallized. And yet, we can be certain that the idea of 'the West' did not simply reflect an already-established western society: rather, it was essential to the very formation of that society.

What is more, the idea of 'the West', once produced, became productive in its turn. It had real effects: it enabled people to know or speak of certain things in certain ways. It produced knowledge. It became *both* the organizing factor in a system of global power relations *and* the organizing concept or term in a whole way of thinking and speaking.

The central concern of this chapter is to analyse the formation of a particular pattern of thought and language, a 'system of representation', which has the concepts of 'the West' and 'the Rest' at its centre.

The emergence of an idea of 'the West' was central to the 'Enlightenment', which was discussed at length in Chapter 1. The Enlightenment was a very European affair. European society, it assumed, was the most advanced type of society on earth, European man (*sic*) the pinnacle of human achievement. It treated the West as the result of forces largely *internal* to Europe's history and formation.

However, in this chapter we argue that the rise of the West is also a *global* story. As Roberts observes, "Modern" history can be defined as the approach march to the age dominated by the West' (Roberts, 1985, p.41). The West and the Rest became two sides of a single coin. What each now is, and what the terms we use to describe them mean, depend on the relations which were established between them long ago. The so-called uniqueness of the West was, in part, produced by Europe's contact and self-comparison with other, non-western, societies (the Rest), very different in their histories, ecologies, patterns of development and cultures from the European model. The difference of these other societies and cultures from the West was the standard against which the West's achievement was measured. It is within the context of these relationships that the idea of 'the West' took on shape and meaning.

The importance of such perceived difference needs itself to be understood. Some modern theorists of language have argued that *meaning* always depends on the relations that exist between the different terms or words within a meaning system (see Chapter 5). Accordingly, we know what 'night' means because it is different from — in fact, opposite to — 'day'. The French linguist who most influenced this approach to meaning, Ferdinand de Saussure (1857–1912), argued that the words 'night' and 'day' on their own can't mean anything; it is

the *difference* between 'night' and 'day' which enables these words to carry meaning (to signify).

Likewise, many psychologists and psychoanalysts argue that an infant first learns to think of itself as a separate and unique 'self' by recognizing its separation — its difference — from others (principally, of course, its mother). By analogy, national cultures acquire their strong sense of identity by contrasting themselves with other cultures. Thus, we argue, the West's sense of itself — its identity — was formed, not only by the internal processes that gradually moulded Western European countries into a distinct type of society, but also through Europe's sense of difference from other worlds — how it came to represent itself in relation to these 'others'. In reality, differences often shade imperceptibly into each other. (When exactly does 'night' become 'day'? Where exactly does 'being English' end and 'being Scottish' begin?). But, in order to function at all, we seem to need distinct, positive concepts many of which are sharply polarized towards each other. As Chapter 5 argues, such 'binary oppositions' seem to be fundamental to all linguistic and symbolic systems and to the production of meaning itself.

This chapter, then, is about the role which 'the Rest' played in the formation of the idea of 'the West' and a 'western' sense of identity. At a certain moment, the fates of what had been, for many centuries, separate and distinct worlds became — some would say, fatally — harnessed together in the same historical time-frame. They became related elements in the same *discourse*, or way of speaking. They became different parts of one global social, economic and cultural system, one interdependent world, one language.

A word of warning must be entered here. In order to bring out the distinctiveness of this 'West and the Rest' discourse, I have been obliged to be selective and to simplify my representation of the West, and you should bear this in mind as you read. Terms like 'the West' and 'the Rest' are historical and linguistic constructs whose meanings change over time. More importantly, there are many different discourses, or ways in which the West came to speak of and represent other cultures. Some, like 'the West and the Rest', were very western-centered, or Eurocentric. Others, however, which I do not have space to discuss here, were much more culturally relativistic. I have elected to focus on what I call the discourse of 'the West and the Rest' because it became a very common and influential discourse, helping to shape public perceptions and attitudes down to the present.

Another qualification concerns the very term 'the West', which makes the West appear unified and homogeneous — essentially one place, with one view about other cultures and one way of speaking about them. Of course, this is not the case. The West has always contained many internal differences — between different nations, between Eastern and Western Europe, between the Germanic Northern and the Latin Southern cultures, between the Nordic, Iberian and Mediterranean peoples, and so on. Attitudes towards other cultures within the West

varied widely, as they still do between, for example, the British, the Spanish, the French and the German.

It is also important to remember that, as well as treating non-European cultures as different and inferior, the West had its own *internal* 'others'. Jews, in particular, though close to western religious traditions, were frequently excluded and ostracized. West Europeans often regarded Eastern Europeans as 'barbaric', and, throughout the West, western women were represented as inferior to western men.

The same necessary simplification is true of my references to 'the Rest'. This term also covers enormous historical, cultural and economic distinctions — for example, between the Middle East, the Far East, Africa, Latin America, indigenous North America and Australasia. It can equally encompass the simple societies of some North American Indians and the developed civilizations of China, Egypt or Islam.

These extensive differences must be borne in mind as you study the analysis of the discourse of 'the West and the Rest' in this chapter. However, we can actually use this simplification to make a point about discourse. For simplification is precisely what this discourse itself *does*. It represents what are in fact very differentiated (the different European cultures) as homogeneous (the West). And it asserts that these different cultures are united by one thing: the fact that *they are all different from the Rest*. Similarly, the Rest, though different among themselves, are represented as the same in the sense that *they are all different from the West*. In short, the discourse, as a 'system of representation', *represents* the world as divided according to a simple dichotomy — the West/the Rest. That is what makes the discourse of 'the West and the Rest' so destructive — it draws crude and simplistic distinctions and constructs an over-simplified conception of 'difference'.

2 EUROPE BREAKS OUT

In what follows, you should bear in mind the evolution of the system of European nation-states discussed in Chapter 2. 'The voyages of discovery were the beginning of a new era, one of world-wide expansion by Europeans, leading in due course to an outright, if temporary, European ... domination of the globe.' (Roberts, 1985, p.175.) In this section we offer a broad sketch of the early stages of this process of expansion. When did it begin? What were its main phases? What did it 'break out' from? Why did it occur?

2.1 WHEN AND HOW DID EXPANSION BEGIN?

Long historical processes have no exact beginning or end, and are difficult to date precisely. You will remember the argument in Chapter 2 that a particular historical pattern is the result of the interplay between a number of different causal processes. In order to describe them, we are

forced to work within very rough-and-ready chronologies and to use *historical generalizations* which cover long periods and pick out the broad patterns, but leave much of the detail aside. There is nothing wrong with this — historical sociology would be impossible without it — provided we know at what level of generality our argument is working. For example, if we are answering the question, ‘When did western Europe first industrialize?’, it may be sufficient to say, ‘During the second half of the eighteenth century’. However, a close study of the origins of industrialization in, say, Lancashire, would require a more refined time-scale. (For further discussion of this point, see the Introduction to this volume.)

We can date the onset of the expansion process roughly in relation to two key events:

- 1 The early Portuguese explorations of the African coast (1430–1498), and
- 2 Columbus’s voyages to the New World (1492–1502).

Broadly speaking, European expansion coincides with the end of what we call ‘the Middle Ages’ and the beginning of the ‘modern age’. Feudalism was already in decline in western Europe, while trade, commerce and the market were expanding. The centralized monarchies of France, England and Spain were emerging (see Chapter 2). Europe was on the threshold of a long, secular boom in productivity, improving standards of living, rapid population growth and that explosion in art, learning, science, scholarship and knowledge known as the Renaissance. (Leonardo had designed flying machines and submarines prior to 1519; Michelangelo started work on the Sistine Chapel in 1508; Thomas Moore’s *Utopia* appeared in 1516). For much of the Middle Ages, the arts of civilization had been more developed in China and the Islamic world than in Europe. Many historians would agree with Michael Mann that, ‘the point at which Europe “overtook” Asia must have been about 1450, the period of European naval expansion and the Galilean revolution in science’; though as Mann also argues, many of the processes which made this possible had earlier origins (Mann, 1988, p.7). We will return to this question at the end of the section.

2.2 FIVE MAIN PHASES

The process of expansion can be divided, broadly, into five main phases:

- 1 The period of exploration, when Europe ‘discovered’ many of the ‘new worlds’ for itself for the first time (they all, of course, already existed).
- 2 The period of early contact, conquest, settlement and colonization, when large parts of these ‘new worlds’ were first annexed to Europe as possessions, or harnessed through trade.